# *Deori* Language: A Historical Overview on its Contemporary Devolution

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**Abstract**

*The Deori language, integral to the cultural identity of the Deori community of Northeast India, is definitely endangered, with only a few thousand speakers remaining. This research investigates the factors contributing to its decline, such as cultural assimilation, urbanisation, and the predominance of Assamese and other regional languages. It also examines the socio-cultural consequences of this endangerment, including the loss of traditional knowledge and the impact on community cohesion. The present study intends to highlight the challenges in revitalising the Deori language, such as limited educational resources, reduced intergenerational transmission, and lack of government support. The present paper aims to explore a comprehensive approach to preservation, including language documentation, community-driven efforts, and the incorporation of Deori into formal education. The study emphasises the importance of preserving the Deori language to maintain the region's cultural and linguistic diversity.*

## Historical Evolution of the *Deori* Language

The *Deori* language, known by its endonym *Jimosaya* (children of the sun and moon) is one of the lesser-known Tibeto-Burman languages. Historically spoken by the Deori community, Encyclopaedia of the World's Endangered Languages categorises Deorias a "severely endangered language" (Moseley 2010).The UNESCO (2009) has explicitly listed Deori as a "definitely endangered" language. The language is primarily spoken

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in the northeastern region of India- Assam and parts of Arunachal Pradesh, including *Lohit* and *Changlang* districts. According to,W.B. Brown,(1895), the Deori community originally inhabited territories beyond Sadiya before undergoing a series of migrations across the Brahmaputra Valley throughout the 18th, 19th and 20th centuries, driven by a mix of environmental disruptions and socio-political pressures (Deori, 2009). Though, presently, Sadiya is a town located in the Tinsukia district of Assam bordering Arunachal Pradesh, in the historical past (12th to 16th centuries), it referred to the Chutiya Kingdom which included the three districts of Lakhimpur, Dhemaji and Tinsukia. Today, Deoris are concentrated along both the banks of the Brahmaputra, particularly in the districts of Lakhimpur, Dhemaji, Sonitpur, Tinsukia, Dibrugarh, Sivasagar and Jorhat (all located in Upper or eastern Assam), with a cultural preference for riverine settlements along the tributaries of the Brahmaputra (Deori, 2009).

The Deori community divides itself into four historically significant sub-groups: *Dibongiya*, *Patorgoyan*, *Borgoyan*, and *Tengaponiya* (Goswami, 1994; Jacquesson, 2005; Deori, 2009; Saikia, 2013). These groupings are named after their original territorial locations—the *Dibongiya* near the *Dibang* river, the *Patorgoyan* in *Pat-Sadiya*, the *Borgoyan* by the *Brahmaputra* (*Borluit*), and the *Tengaponiya* near the *Tengapani* River (Saikia, 2013). Notably, the *Patorgoyan* subgroup has vanished, likely to be subsumed by other groups during migratory phases (Saikia, 2013). Meanwhile, the *Borgoyan* and *Tengaponiya* have largely transitioned to Assamese as their primary language, though they continue to perform social and religious rites in accordance with Deori traditions (Goswami, 1994; Deori, 2002).

The term *Deori* itself carries deep historical significance, referring to the community's longstanding priestly role within Assam's diverse ethnic landscape (Kakati, 1948; Bose, 1967). The Deoris were once designated as the "old priestly caste," administering sacrificial rites for Chutiya and Ahom rulers (Goswami, 1994). This priestly legacy persists, with the Deori community continuing to be distinguished by its religious zeal and adherence to animistic traditions (Deori, 2002; Deori, 2004). Although exposed to Hindu practices through sustained interaction with Assamese society, the Deoris have had retained a belief system that integrates animism with ritualistic practices rooted in their own cosmology (Deori, 2009). Their chief deity, *Kundimama*, is venerated as the ultimate force in nature, accompanied by secondary deities—*Gira-Girasi* or *Bura-Buri*, *Pisa-Dema,* and *PisasiDema*—revered by the *Dibongiya*, *Tengaponiya*, and *Borgoyan* sub-groups, respectively (Goswami, 1994; Deori, 2002; Deori, 2009).

Interestingly, early linguistic scholars (Brown, 1895; Brandreth, 1878; Grierson, 1909) positioned the *Deori* language in close relation to the Chutiya community, erroneously attributing it as the foundational language of Upper Assam (Brown, 1895). *Deori-Chutiya* was initially classified under the Bodo-Garo group, likely to be due to the Deoris' role as ritual specialists within the Chutiya Kingdom. However, recent studies dispel this notion, showing no linguistic or ethnic continuity between the two communities, with neither a shared vocabulary nor a visible socio-cultural link (Deori, 2002). Linguistically, *Deori* exhibits distinctive features indicative of its development

in northeastern Assam, especially around the *Dibang* Valley, an area historically outside Chutiya settlement zones (Jacquesson, 2008).

In terms of classification, Grierson (1909) contended that *Deori*, while generally classified within the *Bodo-Garo* family, retains an "archaic" syntactic structure, diverging sharply from other *Bodo-Garo* languages. Burling (2003) refined this classification by including *Deori* in the *Bodo-Koch* group, arguing that *Garo's* closer linguistic relationship to *Bodo* than to *Koch* justifies a more nuanced *Bodo-Koch* categorisation. Yet, Jacquesson (2005) upholds its *Bodo-Garo* identity, underscoring *Deori's* unique linguistic profile, which distinguishes it from other members of this family. This divergence in classification highlights *Deori's* complex linguistic identity and invites further exploration into its evolution within the Tibeto-Burman family.

**Contemporary Dynamics of the *Deori* Language**

The current state of the *Deori* language and its community is complex and multi-dimensional. While the 2011 census reported 32,376 speakers of *Deori* language within a population of 43,750, local estimates suggest the actual number exceeds 200,000. Many community members feel the official census fails to account for the full *Deori* speaking population, particularly in Assam.

Language transmission within families shows a mixed pattern: children typically learn *Deori* at home but switch to Assamese upon entering the education system. Inter-community marriages contribute to language shifts, with children often adopting Assamese if their *Dibongiya* mother marries outside the community. Conversely, if a non-*Dibongiya* woman marries a *Dibongiya* man, their children are more likely to learn *Deori*. The transmission of *Deori* is generally maintained by older generations, who emphasise the importance of passing the language on, although younger generations use it less frequently.

Apparently, the dominance of Assamese language, the majority and official language of the state, in the educational sphere exacerbates the decline of *Deori* language. Children primarily attend Assamese-medium schools, with wealthier families opting for English-medium institutions. In these contexts, the *Deori* language is often relegated to the home environment, with limited opportunities for its formal or institutional use. Despite this, the language persists in the religious domain, where it remains integral to rituals and ceremonies, including marriage, birth rites, and death rites. Religious hymns and prayers are conducted in *Deori*, and the *Deori Bisu* festival is marked by traditional songs in the language, reinforcing its cultural significance.

The Deori community has had some representation in new media, albeit limited. Two films in *Deori* language were produced in 1999 and 2006, but no new media initiatives have emerged since the 2000s, leaving a gap in its contemporary visibility. A brief radio programme aired in 2002 aimed at promoting the language was discontinued, and no television or radio programming in *Deori* language exists today. The language

also had limited success in print media, with a few initiatives like *Digezi* (a short-lived magazine) and bilingual dictionaries published by institutions like the Anundoram Barooah Institute of Language and Culture (ABILAC). The Deori Sahitya Sabha, a literary organisation, uses the Assamese script for writing in Deori, but the overall reach and accessibility of these publications are limited.

While there is a strong academic interest in *Deori* language, with notable works like Brown (1895), Goswami (1994), Jacquesson (2005), and various research projects documenting its grammar and socio-cultural aspects, the community still faces challenges in accessing these materials. Lack of awareness, inadequate dissemination, and limited interaction between language experts and community members contribute to this gap.

Nevertheless, on a positive note, this has been noticed of late that the Deori community has made some significant efforts to safeguard their language and culture. Organisations like the All Assam Deori Sanmilan, 1936, All Assam Deori Student's Union, 1959 and TheDeori Sahitya Sabha1965 have advocated for the recognition and promotion of the language. In 2005, the Deori Autonomous Council was formed as a result of the Deori Accord,2005 which aimed to protect the community's socio-cultural identity. While the community has lobbied for recognition under the Sixth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, which would grant greater autonomy, this request has yet to be fulfilled.

The Deori Sahitya Sabhahas also pushed for the inclusion of *Deori* language in school curriculam and the appointment of teachers teaching the language in schools. Although *Deori* was officially recognised as a language in Assam's educational system in 2005, its implementation has been hindered by a shortage of qualified teachers. Some years back,Dibrugarh University has taken steps to address this gap by offering a certificate course in *Deori* language which aims to teach young adults the language but it was discontinued due to lack of trained teachers.Community members emphasise that introducing *Deori* language in the school curriculum at an early age would be more effective for ensuring its long-term vitality.

Despite these challenges, the *Deori* language seems not to be on the verge of total extinction though. It is because of the community's positive attitude towards their language, coupled with their efforts to teach it to younger generations. Under these circumstances, this may be viewed that preservation is still possible. The qualitative data already points to a promising outlook if interventions rather encouragements are made at the right stage of education. The community's commitment to maintaining *Deori* as a living language depends on addressing the structural issues limiting its transmission and institutional support.

**Factors Contributing to Linguistic Devolution**

The *Deori* language, belonging to the Tibeto-Burman linguistic family, has undergone significant changes over time due to various historical, socio-political and migratory

factors. Once a thriving language spoken by all Deoris, its devolution can be traced through different phases of migration, political upheavals and cultural assimilation.

During the pre-colonial period, under Chutiya (1187 CE-1524 CE) and Ahom rule (1228 CE-1826 CE) respectively, the *Deori* language flourished as it was closely associated with religious and administrative functions. The Deoris, who served as temple priests, held a significant position. They were granted *Devottar* and *Brahmottar* lands during the Ahom rule, which allowed them to sustain their religious and linguistic traditions (Deori,1964). The language was widely used in temple rituals, social gatherings and everyday life within the community. However, this linguistic continuity appears to have first disrupted during the Moamoria rebellions (1769 CE-1805 CE) which almost shook the very foundation of the Ahom Kingdom, the political hub of medieval Northeast India. In fact, the very first phase of the rebellion (1769 CE-1770 CE) had greatly destabilised the Ahom kingdom, and it is well implied that this political debacle led to the initial displacement of several communities including the Deoris from their early settlements. Despite this, the community retained their language with their continued temple duties.

The 18th century brought further disruptions to the Deori settlements, primarily due to external invasions and internal conflicts. The Mishmi (a major tribe of Arunachal Pradesh) and Burmese invasions beyond the Patkai mountains, along with the incursions of the Khamtisand Singphos in the 19th century created instability in Sadiya region, the traditional stronghold of Deori community. One of the most devastating event was the assassination of the last *Bordeori* (chief priest) at the *Tameswari Mai* temple (attributed to the fierce goddess Tamreswari or Kechai-khati)in 1793, which marked a turning point in the decline of the Deori community as priests in religious institutions of Sadiya.Many people including the Deoris also fled from Sadiya to different places to save themselves from the Khamti onslaughts in the 19th century (Barua, 1972; Barua & Nath, 1990). This period evidently initiated the first stage of language shift, as displaced Deoris had to adapt to new linguistic environments.

With the advent of British rule following the treaty of Yandaboo (1826), the *Deori* language faced further marginalisation. The British administration introduced Assamese as the medium of governance and education, sidelining indigenous languages like *Deori*. The community's dispersal during the British period also played a crucial role in the decline of the language. As the Deoris migrated to different parts of the Brahmaputra Valley, the fragmentation of their settlements led to a breakdown in linguistic continuity. By the late 19th century, two of the three major clans *Borgoyan* and *Tengaponiyas* had abandoned the *Deori* dialect entirely, adopting Assamese as their primary language. Only the *Dibongiya* clan retained the dialect but even they faced pressure, of course unintentional, from the Assamese speaking population constituting the dominant class (Deori, 1964).

The mid-20th century brought another wave of challenges for the *Deori* language. The 1950 Assam earthquake along with subsequent floods and riverbank erosion, displaced

many Deori families, forcing them to migrate further into Assamese dominated regions. Economic survival became a priority and this further accelerated the linguistic shift, as younger generations found it more practical to communicate in Assamese language on a daily basis. By the late 20thcentury,the *Deori* language had become a language of ritual and ceremonial use rather than everyday communication.

Language Contact and Assimilation: The constant interaction between *Deori* and *Assamese* has profoundly impacted *Deori's* phonology and vocabulary. The language shift is evident in the younger generation's speech, which shows signs of tonal erosion—a consequence of the non-tonal nature of Assamese. As Assamese is the dominant language in education and administration, *Deori* speakers have become increasingly bilingual, often code-switching or entirely replacing *Deori* with Assamese in many contexts. This linguistic assimilation has further weakened *Deori's* status, contributing to its gradual decline.

Further, cultural assimilation, facilitated by inter-community marriages and the adoption of Assamese customs, has accelerated the decline of the *Deori* language. Education in Assam is primarily conducted in Assamese, with few opportunities for children to learn *Deori* formally. Consequently, younger generations are more fluent in Assamese, reserving *Deori* for interactions with older family members or for religious rituals. The limited use of *Deori* in everyday communication has led to a progressive loss of linguistic features and vocabulary.

The efforts to document *Deori* began in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. The works of Brown and Grierson provided early grammatical descriptions, but comprehensive documentation remained limited. In more recent years, the Deori Sahitya Sabha and other academic institutions have sought to preserve the language through compiling dictionaries, grammar books, and phonetic studies. Despite these efforts, the lack of widespread access to these resources remains a challenge. The language's phonological studies, particularly focusing on tonal variation among the different generations reveal the extent of linguistic erosion.

**Revitalisation Efforts and Future Prospects**

The Deori Accord of 2005 led to the establishment of the *Deori* Autonomous Council, aimed at preserving *Deori* culture and language. While the council has made some progress, such as supporting cultural events and publishing educational materials, more comprehensive measures are needed. For instance, appointing Deori teachers and incorporating the language into school curricula would be a significant step forward. The initiative undertaken by the Dibrugarh University in introducing a six-month certificate course in *Deori* language is a positive development in this direction; but broader educational reforms are equally required.

Certain community organisations like the Deori Sahitya Sabha and the All Assam Deori Students Union have already started playing a crucial role in language preservation.

These groups have organised cultural festivals, published literary works, and lobbied for governmental support. However, the lack of sustained funding and organisational coordination hampers their efforts. In this connection, the digital platforms may offer new opportunities for engagement, especially among the youth, who could be encouraged to use *Deori* in social media and content creation.

Reviving the critically endangered *Deori* language requires adopting strategies from successful global examples of language revitalisation. One of the most remarkable efforts in language revival is that of Hebrew, which was transformed from a liturgical language to a spoken one under the leadership of *EliezerBen-Yehuda*. Years ago, by integrating Hebrew into daily life, education, and governance, it became the cornerstone of modern Israel. Similarly, the *Deori* language can be revitalised by encouraging its use in everyday conversations, traditional ceremonies, and local governance. Promoting *Deori* as the language of communication in festivals, cultural gatherings, and community meetings can restore its relevance and utility in daily life.

The *Maori* revival in New Zealand highlights the power of immersive education. Through *Kohanga Reo* (language nests) and Maori-medium schools, young Maori children were immersed in their language, ensuring its transmission to future generations. This model can be adapted for *Deori* by establishing *Deori Bhasa Kendras*—community-based language immersion programmes for children. Schools in *Deori*-speaking regions can incorporate *Deori* as a medium of instruction alongside Assamese and English, fostering bilingual or trilingual proficiency while rooting students in their cultural heritage.

Legal recognition and media support have played a significant role in preserving Welsh in Wales. The Welsh Language Act (1993) and initiatives like Welsh-medium education, along with platforms such as S4C, a Welsh-language TV channel, have contributed to the growth of Welsh speakers. For *Deori*, similar steps can include legal recognition of the language within Deori-dominated areas and the establishment of *Deori*-language media platforms, such as radio programmes, TV shows, and social media channels. These initiatives would make the language visible, accessible, and appealing, especially to younger generations.

Ireland's efforts to revive Irish Gaelic underscore the importance of integrating language into education and cultural promotion. By making Irish a mandatory subject in schools, the Irish government ensured its systematic teaching. Likewise, introducing *Deori* as a compulsory subject in schools in *Deori*-speaking areas can institutionalise its learning. Organising cultural festivals, folk music programmes, and storytelling sessions in *Deori* can foster a deep emotional connection with the language, making it a source of pride and identity for the community.

The revival of the *Cornish* language (*kernewek*) is one of the most remarkable language revitalisation efforts in the United Kingdom. Although *Cornish* ceased to be spoken as a first language by the late 18$^{th}$century, linguists successfully reconstructed it in 20$^{th}$ century using historical records and oral traditions. This model offers valuable insights

for the standardisation of the *Deori* language.By compiling existing manuscripts, oral traditions, and recorded phrases, linguists and community leaders can work together to develop a uniform script and grammar, ensuring consistency in teaching and usage.

It is a well-known fact that grassroots efforts have been pivotal in reviving languages like Hawaiian and Wampanoag. In Hawaii, the establishment of Hawaiian-medium schools and cultural programmes revitalised the language. The *Wopanaak* Language Reclamation Project has even enabled some tribal children to grow up as native speakers of *Wampanoag*. For *Deori*, grassroots initiatives led by the community, such as language workshops, teachers-training programmes, and family-based language use, can ensure its transmission to the next generation. Forming a *Deori* Language Revival Committee can help organise and implement these efforts effectively.

Likewise, cultural centres and classes have been instrumental in preserving endangered languages like Japan's *Ainu*. Establishing *Deori* language and cultural centres can provide spaces for teaching, research, and community gatherings. These centres could document and preserve oral traditions, folk songs, and rituals, ensuring that the rich cultural heritage associated with *Deori* language and the culture are not lost.

Reviving a language is not just about preserving words; it is about safeguarding the identity and pride of a community. Like other languagesundergoing revival, the *Deori* language holds deep cultural and historical significance. By fostering a sense of pride in their linguistic heritage, the Deori people can inspire the younger generation to embrace and use the language in their daily lives.

Lastly, the role of government and NGOs in language revival cannot be overstated. Financial and institutional support is crucial for implementing language programmes. Collaborations with universities and research institutions can help create digital resources like mobile apps, online dictionaries, and learning platforms for *Deori*. By combining community-driven efforts with institutional support, the *Deori* language can be revitalised, preserving its legacy for future generations.

**Conclusion**

The Deori language, though critically endangered, is not beyond saving and remains an integral part of the community's cultural heritage.This study has traced its historical evolution, examined the factors contributing to its decline, and explored the challenges of revitalisation. The forces of cultural assimilation, urbanisation and the dominance of Assamese have significantly eroded its usage, yet the resilience of the Deori people offers a path forward.

Preserving *Deori* requires a comprehensive approach that includes integrating the language into formal education, securing government recognition and support, and fostering community-led initiatives.Drawing from examples of successful language revitalisation, strategies such as immersive education, media representation and legal protections can play a crucial role in its survival. Strengthening intergenerational

transmission and expanding its presence in public life will be essential to reversing its decline.

Ultimately, safeguarding the *Deori* language is not just about linguistic preservation, it is about protecting the identity, traditions and collective memory of an entire community. With sustained commitment from both institutional and grassroots efforts, *Deori* can be revitalised, ensuring its continuity for future generations.

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